Ludus

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra, Adora, Shadow Weaver, Hordak, Lonnie, Glimmer, Bow, Angela, Prime

Additional Tags:
Etheria is Ancient Rome, LOTS of violence, Catra is the lion you are thrown to, Adora is a gladiatrix, Shadow Weaver is the Domina, fleeting implication of sexual assault, main character injury

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by limey_limey

Summary

Adora grows up in the Ludus, training to be a gladiatrix is all she knows. One day her Domina charges her with feeding the young lion that is caged in the training area and a bond is forged between the warrior and the lion that spans a lifetime.

Notes

I had no idea that there was a TV show called Domina on right now! I had this idea re-watching Starz Spartacus.

If you're waiting on Hidden Kingdom I wrote this because I was stuck but I am now half way through an update for that so it’s coming.

Small hands scooped up sand and watched it fall in golden streams back to join the grains on the ground. The child did this over and over, almost hypnotised by the repetitive motion. Around her the other children ran and screamed, burning off energy between training sessions. Adora preferred to sit quietly and think about what they had learned, letting the information seep into her very bones. She was still small, much smaller than all of the other initiates, she wasn't sure how old she was, none of them were, but sometimes she knew that she had to think harder and concentrate more than the others. Her sober little face was a little swollen along her right cheek from a hard kick she had failed to dodge the day before, the skin yellowing and sickly looking but she hd been proud not to lose any teeth.

Clanging echoing around the training ground brought all the children up short, all their noise ceasing. Adora looked up, the metallic sound similar to the practice gong but not quite right. Her eyes scanned around the wide sanded area, seeing that the large wooden doors at the end were slowly being pushed open. The noise sounded again, and now all of the children realised that it was coming from the outside. Like birds, they scattered from their places, moving close to the doors to see what the commotion was. The older fighters ignored the commotion and continued to shovel their food into their mouths under the shade of the simple wooden awning that acted as dining room here. They had seen people and things come and go, whatever was about to arrive through those doors they would undoubtedly face on the sand soon enough.

Bright blue eyes stayed fixed on the widening gap between the doors the jangling and scraping of metal accompanied by the pained screams of some kind of wounded animal. The blond child was crouched behind a couple of crates that contained wooden training weapons, hidden from view as she waited to see. She knew that most of the other children didn't like her. She was an exceptional fighter even at her young age, and would regularly be pitted against much older kids in practice bouts by the Domina,

usually coming out the victor and having praise lavished on her at the expense of the other initiates. It didn't make her very popular.

She could stop trying so hard, let herself loose once in a while, but she relished the praise and attention. If she won, Domina would take her into the big house and let her sit on her knee and eat from her plate. Sometimes Dominus would congratulate her and offer her a candy. When she did especially well, she was allowed to sleep in a special room inside the house and Domina would recount stories of amazing prowess in the arena. Of valiant warriors whose names had been chanted and who had gone down in history. It was all Adora wanted, to make them proud of her. She had heard, in the rumours around the barracks that sometimes fighters got to go and live normal lives, and she thought that if she was good enough maybe she would get to live in the house for always.

The doors finally flying open to crash against the walls on either side, sending up a plume of dust and sand, made the girl jump in her hiding spot. A phalanx of men marched in, their shining carapaces glinting in the sun while the plumed helmets fluttered with the breeze as they marched in perfect synchronicity. It was unusual to see soldiers on the sands, they looked so different to the men and women who lounged with only fleeting curiosity in the shade. Everything bit them was clean, lean and purposeful, no effort waisted as they moved. Behind them came a large cage, held on the back of a wheeled pallet, pulled by a pair of horses. Adora could't make out what was inside the cage and pulled herself up on top of the boxes to get a better view. Even then, all she would make up was a small dark ball in one corner of the massive enclosure.

Familiar footfalls entering the training ground sent a ripple of chaos around the area, as now all of the trainees and initiates took up their familiar place in the centre of the sand. They formed perfect rows, the youngest initiates at the front, the oldest and most experienced at the back. It took moments and then there was only the sound of creaking wheels and clanging metal. The Dominus and Domina surveyed their people with pleased

expressions on their faces and Adora felt her small chest puff out and noticed that similar was true for her peers. Then the well dressed pair were moving to meet the leader of the soldier's.

This soldier was set apart by the bright red accents that peeked out between the metal and leather. She had one hand clasped to the pommel of her sword where it sat at her hip while the other moved to pull of her helmet, revealing a tanned face and pointed ears. She bowed respectfully to the richly robed couple.

"As requested, we have brought you a lion cub. It was the only one that we located while in the woods." Domina and Dominus had moved passed her as she spoke, heading towards the large cage. "We had anticipated finding more, hence the size of the cage."

Hordak looked to Shadow Weaver, an expression on his angular face unreadable to anyone but those closest to him. He was pleased, being the only ones to have possession of a coveted lion would do wonders for their wins and their revenue. Had the Captain located more, they would have been sold to other Ludus' and that was just bad for business. He held out his arm, Shadow Weaver delicately resting her hand on his forearm as they finally reached the cage, her face inscrutable beneath her elegantly wrought mask.

"This is all you found?" The voice that came out of the masked woman was full of derision as she ran her eyes over the tiny form cowering in the cage.

"We located a colony, all of the others were dead, ripped to pieces by something much larger it appeared. We wouldn't have even noticed this little one if she hadn't crawled out mewling from beneath the body of a large female." The soldier had joined them at the cage, looking at the balled up creature within. "It might be young, but it has a will to survive like I have seldom seen. The soldier that attempted to capture it was slashed so badly across the throat that had we not been accompanied by a magic user, he would have bled out. It's fast and stronger than it looks. Once it

grows up you will have a hell of weapon on your hands." She walked away, giving instructions to the servants that had started to mill around, about how to unload the cage.

Dominus walked to join them, pointing to the covered area away to the side of the practice grounds where the cage was to be kept. Adora watched as Domina stayed behind, facing the cage. She had heard some of what had been said, carried over by the wind, but she had no idea what a lion was, though from the gasps of the older fighters at her back, the same was not true for them. For a moment she thought that they sounded afraid, which was ridiculous because nobody in the Ludus was ever afraid.

That night, Adora was brought into the big house. She sat on Domina's knee and got fed the tastiest treats from her plate while the tall woman stroked her hair and told her what a good girl she was. It had been a strange day, after the cage had been placed into the shade and the soldier's had bid farewell, training had resumed with all of them knowing better than to pay attention to the new arrival. If Adora had let her eyes glance that way once or twice, she certainly hadn't let it stop her from dumping Kyle on his butt. Twice. It wasn't a great achievement, every initiate could take down Kyle, but still Domina had called for her. Perhaps it was because she was so young that Adora never noticed the glowers of the children who were never called into the house, but she had trotted away without a care in the word.

When dinner was done and the house servants had come to clean away the food, wearing their pretty, shiny collars that were different from the tough leather that surrounded her own neck, Dominus took his leave, walking out of the front door with barely a word, while Domina hoisted the little girl onto her hip and walked out of the double doors that let to the viewing platform. At this time of day the training grounds were empty, the elders taking their final meal and the children already in their beds. Setting herself into her throne-like chair overlooking the training area, Domina arranged the little child on her lap, cupping her jaw and looking into trusting eyes.

Shadow Weaver inspected the young face that looked up at her with trusting eyes the colour of a summer's day. There was something about this little girl that stood out among the rank and file below. She was a head and shoulders about any of the others, rivalling even some of the seasoned veterans with her skills with the blade even at such a tender age.

The day she had seen the sullen faced toddler on the block she had known that they need to buy her. Hordak had been bound and determined to purchase some new studs for their stable, and had grumbled when she had walked away from him and towards the seller hawking house slaves. The tiny blond had been no more than eighteen months, huge eyes in a full cheeked face as she stood and faced the crowd with defiance written all over her. All the other children around her were quaking and crying but she had her feet planted and her shoulders squared as she looked out at the people who would possess her. Shadow Weaver had raised her hand, much to Hordak's consternation where he had joined her peering at the children questioningly, and called out.

"A silver for the blond." Her velvety voice cut through the hubbub and drew the attention of the vendor who fell over himself to get to her.

The Dominus and Domina of the Horde Ludus were well known at the market, they trained some of the best gladiators that Etheria had seen and were ruthless in discarding those who did not measure up. Their initiate purchases were never done in person, they would simply order a new batch of children and return those who showed no promise. Now, here they were here selecting one of his new brood in person. It would make him the talk of the town and others were bound to flock to his block after this.

"Of course, Shadow Weaver! She is from our finest stock and is a blank canvass to be mould…" A long fingered hand came up to forestall his words and he was left with his mouth flapping open like a landed fish.

“You’ve already made a sale, spare us.” The statuesque woman hidden behind the iconic mask walked through the crowd that parted for her and reached up to take hold of the child who gave no resistance when she was lifted into silk covered arms. Hordak threw a sneer at the vendor, along with the gold coin that hit the flaw and caused him to grovel in the dirt to pick it up.

Hordak looked at the woman by his side, his Domina. There was no-one else he would trust to help him run the Ludus and if she saw promise in this infant then there must be promise there to see. His red eyes looked at the girl child now held in her arms, looking up at her mask in awe, and saw nothing but a drain on his resources. The initiates were of no use to him until they could hit the sands of the arena and fight and die for his advancement.

Three years later and if Adora’s training continued to go as smoothly as it began she would be the finest gladiatrix that the sands had ever seen. “Adora,” her voice broke the child from the faint doze she had fallen into in her arms. “I have a job for you.”

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She was alone.

The world around her was silent, more quiet than anywhere she had ever been. The forest was loud day and night, life seeping out of every quarter. The birds, the crickets and even the ants would move the air around. There was no life here, only metal and sand.

She hadn’t moved from her balled up position at the corner of the cage until the night moon was full. As darkness fell life drained from the place, the people who had populated the sands, swiping at each other with weapons made for fragile hands filed away until there were none. Torches were extinguished and the gates locked. All that was left in the world was a single figure standing at the gate, clearly a guard and the small ball of fur.

Certain that her spot was dark enough to shield her from view she uncoiled and stretched. She flexed her tiny claws and tried to

groom the worst of the dried blood and dirt out of her fur with claws and tongue. It was futile but felt comforting. Usually her mother would groom her after her bath in the river. It soothed her before she would curl up in the pile with the others and go to sleep. The pile of young would be warm and safe, the adults arrayed around them to keep them safe.

No-one had seen the slug coming, one minute they had been lounging in the light, bellies full of the latest kill that had been dragged back to the tribe, the next it had burst through the trees and been upon them. There was no chance of stopping it, no matter how many brave warriors launched their bodies at it, hacking away with their razor sharp claws or biting down with savage intensity. They were thrown this way and then, falling in limp, lifeless heaps all around until all that was left were the young, huddling together as the monsters giant maw gaped wide and devoured them. She had survived, cowering under the body of one of the dead warriors, struck mute by the terror of what she had seen.

She was young, her concept of time loose, but then there had been people in the clearing picking over the bodies and disrupting the flies who burst away from the corpses like a black cloud of death, surrounding the living like a pall. The tiny, weak one had cowered once again, but when the smell of fresh meat hit her nostrils, sweet and clean over the rancid odour of decay, she had surged out of her hiding place only to be scooped upland held in the air by a stranger. She had seen red, fear racing through her, and with all her fading strength, lashed out with her claws, dragging them across a soft throat as she had been shown by her elders. He had been unprepared for the sudden, frenetic attack and soon blood was gushing from the gaping wound, splattering over the child’s face and she licked her lips greedily, the warm salty taste slaking come of the gnawing hunger in her belly. As her captor fell, she was snatched away by the scruff of her neck and thrown roughly into the back of the cage she now found herself confined to.

There had been meat in the cage, enough for a dozen adults, and she had thrown her tiny body onto it, gorging until her belly was bloated and fat. She had wretched then, throwing up all over herself and the left over meat. It wasn't until the cage and the people with it came to a river that they stopped and she was being dragged back out of the cage. She was too dazed by hunger, sickness and fear to run, and even less prepared for being thrown into the pool of water and held down. She had found weakly against the hand on her head, swiping at it with her small claws until she was lifted out of the water and shaken roughly enough to make her teeth rattle. She wasn't clean but at least much of the smell of decay and all of the vomit were gone from her fur.

The journey had lasted long enough for her belly to no longer be warped and distended and most of her childish strength to have returned. Now she was wherever they had intended for her to be. Her tribe were one of few living wild and free in the woods across the land. They kept away from civilisation and lived with nature, even if sometimes nature fought back and won, but they were not animals as these people seemed to believe. Every one of her tribe had known the words of the cities. She had heard some things that she had no comprehension of, Lions and arenas, but the idea she heard well enough. She belonged to somewhere new now. Perhaps if she was good enough they would let her out of the cage and she would have a new home.

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Adora woke up in the soft, downy comfort of the special bed. She snuggled further under the sweet smelling sheets a nuzzled her face into the pillow. The cock had yet to crow, so she knew that she had time to just enjoy the comfort and warmth. It was a far cry from the firm canvas and scratchy blanket of her cell in the training area below. She cracked open her eyes in time to see the first hazy light of day filter through the window. Maybe she could have a few more minutes.

Blue eyes started to flutter closed again, a small hand balling under her chin, clutching at the sheets. Just as her breath began to even out again she jerked up, springing to her feet and standing beside the bed breathing rapidly. She had a job to do this morning, she couldn't forget.

Pulling her hair back into a ponytail and puling on her training shift, she skipped out of the bedroom and back down to the training area. The cock crowed as she walked to the mess and smiled, gap toothed, at the cook holding out two bowls. A dollop of something like porridge was ladled into one and then a raised brow was directed at the other. No matter how likeable Adora might be, children only received one bowl.

"Domina told me to bring meat to the lion." She held out the empty bowl and had it taken from her while the cook wandered out of the door to the cold room returning swiftly with a dish full of bloody meat chunks.

"There you go, m'girl." The large woman smiled down at her.

She thanked her before running off, out of the mess and towards the shadowed cage. As she got closer, careful not to drop any of the food, she could see that the small form inside was still balled up, though in a different corner. Adora sat herself down in the dust beside the cage, far enough away to avoid the swipe of a hand but close enough to be able to lean forward and push the bowl through the small slot at the bottom. She waited a moment before she pulled the spoon from her porridge and licked off the goopy mixture before using the utensil to clang against a bar, seeing the figure in the corner flinch.

"Hello!" Her voice was light and happy, it usually was, she had learned that being upbeat got her further with the Doctore than the surely attitude of some of the others.

There was no response from inside, though she was pretty sure that she saw an ear twitch. She started to eat her own breakfast, forcing herself to eat much slower than she normally would have.

She hummed and made sounds of pleasure as she consumed the creamy mess, eyes never straying from the thing in the cage. There was a definite shiver of movement now that she watched.

"Breakfast is yummy. You should have some. I put some meat here but Domina says I'm not allowed to leave it if you don't eat with me." She leaned forward expectantly.

Her words were rewarded with a little, squeaky growl as the thing in the corner uncurled to reveal a child, a little smaller than herself, covered in fur. In fact, the child looked much more like a young animal than a person, ears and tail twitching as all four limbs touched the floor as though it was ready to pounce. A large mane surrounded her head, almost as big as the child itself.

Adora locked eyes with the oddly coloured ones in front of her. They seemed to glow in the shadows. Adora smiled at it and stuffed another spoon into her mouth, cheeks puffing up as she chewed. Cautiously the small animal edged towards the bowl of meat, finally coming to sit in a pose mirroring Adora's own, then leaned forward and skewered a cube of meat with a dangerous looking claw and bringing it up to sniff experimentally before popping it into a fanged mouth and chewing.

"Is it good?" Adora was curious, the idea of eating raw meat was revolting to her but she was a person not an animal.

To answer the little creature scooped up the bowl and held it in their lap as they fisted meat into their mouth, blood oozing into the already filthy fur on its chin. Adora's bowl was empty and she set it on the ground beside her, hearing the stirring of the others moving from their cells and into the mess behind her. Her attention was still fixed on the animal who had set their own empty bowl on the floor, pushing it back to Adora through the bars.

"Thank you." Adora got to her knees and shuffled forward to take the item, careful not to get grabbed. As she got closer, a stomach

roiling odour filled her nose and she moved back as quickly as she could. They needed to wash the little thing in there.

"Do you have a name?" The thing looked so much like a person, it was hard to think it wouldn't be able to talk. "I'm Adora." She beamed as she pointed to her own chest.

The other child knew of names, had overheard the people who passed through the woods use them. It was why her tribe knew the words of the people, to keep them safe from any potential invaders or hunters. People would pass just inches below them as they roamed the canopy of the trees, blissfully unaware of their observers, and they would pick up any useful information about what was happening in the world of man to keep far from it. Her tribe didn't have names in the same way. The smell, taste and feel of another were what identified them among the others. She missed her mother's scent. She locked eyes with the well meaning child and shook her head.

"You understand me though?" It was very exciting to find that out, she wondered if the Domina knew it could understand. The animal nodded, never looking away. "Yay! We can be friends! I was the littlest one here, now you're here. I'm going to call you Catra! It's like my name so we can be best friends now."

"Ok." She wasn't used to the feel of the people words in her mouth, but the single sound came out clearly enough. The girl opposite clapped her hands and giggled in delight.

The ringing of a gong disturbed the pair and Catra retreated back into a ball in her corner. Adora scooped up the two dirty dishes and waved over her shoulder as she ran to put them back in the mess before training began. Catra watched the people accumulate on the sand in two distinct groups. The one that contained Adora was larger, children ranging from her own age to older youths all arrayed together. The other had fewer people but they were all adults and obviously battle hardened if the scars and muscles were anything to go by. The casual ease with which they held

their bodies at the ready was soothingly reminiscent of her own elders.

Drills began and smaller groups formed moving their bodies in patterns that were obviously familiar to them. As Catra watched with the attentiveness possessed by cats, assessing and ready to spot a weakness, prepared to pounce. They had not been working for long when a new figure appeared. This one was familiar, one of the people who had spoken outside her cage the day before. Her long red robes were made out of fine, shimmering material and her face was obscured by some sort of shield but she was clearly powerful from the way all of the warriors on the sand instantly stopped and stiffened at her approach. Catra watched as she made her way to the small form of Adora and cupped her face in her hand. It was curious to see the human child nuzzle into the touch much as a kit would.

Shadow Weaver bent down, "Adora, did you feed the animal?"

"Yes, Domina. It ate the food and I found out that it can understand what we are saying." She cast her eyes around and then leaned closer to tall woman and whispered in that loud way children have. "I named it Catra." She seemed very please by that.

"Then Catra it is, not for the arena of course." It cost nothing to humour her favourite as long as she knew her place.

"She's real smelly, Domina." Adora's snub nose wrinkled adorably, Shadow Weaver's heart would have melted if she hadn't hardened it a lifetime ago.

"Then we shall have to make her clean, we don't want any fleas here."

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Catra was dragged out of her cage by a chain looped through the ring at the front of her collar, it chaffed against the skin that had been worn bare by the metal. Heavy hands pulled hard, leaving her no choice but to move forward or be choked. She knew that

an elder would be able to slice through the chain with their claws and free themselves, but she was still young yet. The door at the end of the cage moved up and she was on the hot sand surrounded by the grim faces of those whose training had ceased for the morning as the sun grew too hot.

They filed away, Adora throwing her a wave as she joined the others who were much more accommodating of the taller and more gangly blond now than when the cat-girl had first arrived. Her musings were cut short by the icy cold hit of the buckets of water that were thrown over her. Her breath caught even though she had come to expect it. Then the rough bristles of the brushes held on long sticked were scrubbing the blood and mess from her fur. It was weekly ritual to clean the filth from their lion. Another bucket followed, turning the sand under her feet rusty. She shook the remaining water off of her and was dragged back into the cage that had also had a sluicing.

Shivering in the shade, Adora's footfalls made her ears perk up and Catra sat straighter, training her eyes on the walkway. When Adora walked to her, their food in her hands, a smile crossed the feline face. As she walked the other little girl went in and out of beans of sunlight as they shone through the thatched roof of the place. It made her hair sparkle golden and her skin look like alabaster. Adora was all the companionship and safety that she had here. The other initiates would sometimes bring her food, or be forced to interact with her but their loathing was always clear. They knew what she was for.

"Look, our food's almost the same today!" Adora's voice was cheery as the platter of meat was slid through the bars and she plopped to the ground. Unlike when they first met, Adora sat with her shoulder leaning against the cool metal now, so close that Catra could rip out her throat is she chose. She never would.

"How can your food be like mine, dummy?" Catra spoke around a mouthful of juicy meat.

“It’s stew, just lots of meat chunks in soup.” She held the bowl for her friend to see, cursing under her breath when some fell onto her bare leg that poked out from the edge of her tunic. Without thought the other child reached through the bars and swiped the spilled food before bringing to her mouth to lick it off of her palm. She recoiled from the taste and Adora laughed at the expression on her face.

“You keep that.” They ate in companionable silence.

Catra had been at the ludus for almost two years now and she and Adora were the best of friends. It was something that perplexed Domina, who had not envisaged that her favourite would go from tool to manipulate the little cat to friends with it. She was displeased but had not put a stop to it as Adora remained just as eager to please as always. The fact that Catra stayed in the cage unless she was being exercised meant that she had total control over their interactions anyway.

While the lunch period continued, the pair of children played games through the bars, sometimes joined by the other younger initiates. Adora was far more popular now, just as tall as the next oldest children and still the most accomplished pf them all. Petty jealousies still existed but most had realised that being in the blond’s good graces served them better. Catra wasn’t so keen on these interlopers on her time with her friends but it made Adora happy so she tried to be happy.

A bulky shadow fell over them. It was time for Catra to train. Her sessions were usually kept after hours once all of the others had been sent off to their cells. But battles were not fought at night, they were fought under the punishing rays of the sun on sand made hot and sharp. Once a week the lion was let out of her cage and violence was thrown at her. Keys jangled and with practiced resignation the small child offered the collar around her neck for the chain before the door was opened and she was led out. She had long since stopped fighting this, she was young and small, far weaker than her captors and knew there was no way out. She was simply biding her time, she told herself.

The child was led out into the middle of the training sands, bare pads of her feet burning from lack of exercise. They should be resilient and able to take on any terrain but pacing her cage was unhelpful with that. Her chain was tied to a ring protruding from the top of the whipping post and she was as free as she could. She jumped up and down, ran around the post, the chain was long so her laps were broad. Soon her muscles were warmed up, the fur over her body puffed up and her ears twitching, waiting for the inevitable ambush.

When it came, the quarter it came from was always a surprise. Sometimes a group of initiates would converge on her, others one of the large adults would wail on her. They were armed. She was not. She could hold her own, even though she was still small and slight, her claws hard enough now to rip through leather armour and leave more than a scar or two on torsos and thighs. It was never enough though, the two robed people who watched from the balcony never gave praise on censure. She already knew the bite of the ship on her skin when she was too wilful or not aggressive enough.

Today she waited, ears pricked and feet planted. It had been a good week, she was clean and well fed. Nobody was going to best her today. She bared her teeth and growled, ears flicking as she picked up on the sudden rush of lighter footsteps. Initiates it was today. She could probably make a couple cry, though she had learned a lesson early on that permanently damaging any of them would get her badly hurt in response. Octavia still glared at her with her one good eye and was just spoiling for a chance at her.

The first blow came from behind, the noise ahead a distraction from the person at her back. A cudgel hit her across the skull with force, making her ears ring and leaving her staggering. She whirled on her attacker, only to be caught from the side, effectively disorientated. Something happened then, a fire that she hadn’t felt coursed through her and she let out a scream as she lashed out with her claws in a frenzy of pain and confusion. She felt her claws rip through soft flesh again and gain, no more blows finding her as she surged forward, vision still blurred. She

was coiled to pounce on a blurry figure, when a crushing blow smashed into her ribs and used her own momentum to send her flying sideways coming to a stop as she hit the whipping post. All the air was gone from her lungs and distantly she could hear clapping.

Sand crunched under delicate heels as the Domina took to the sand. The initiates who had been injured by the small ball of fury already dragged from the training area, the others stood to attention. Catra remained a crumpled heap, clutching her ribs. The feet got closer and closer, the little girl wishing that she were brave enough to swipe out at the legs that were now in view, but she was a coward. A velvet shoe nudged her jaw, lifting her chin until she was forced to look up at the impassive mask.

"You remain a pathetic waste of food. I cannot believe that Ludus Selineas got a full grown lion and we got stuck with you." The foot moved away and Catra barely stifled a growl, the hostility in her eyes only making the tall woman shake her head. "Maybe you'd make a better rug." The words were menacingly thrown at her as the Domina made her way to the assembled initiates.

Shadow Weaver loathed the animal that lay in the dirt. By now she should have grown larger than her counterparts, yet she was still a runt, short and scrawny. Giving her the best meat to help her grow had done nothing but put a dent in their coffers that the young lion hadn't won. Moving away from the disappointment, reminding herself to burn her shoes when she reentered the house, she headed towards her favourite. The ambush had been Adora's plan, she had effectively deployed the others and they had fallen in line. The blond had shown a willingness to put some in peril in order to win the larger fight. She had also shown that no matter how enamoured she may seem with the animal, she knew that she was a training tool.

"Adora, you performed wonderfully today. You and your team will all receive extra rations today." A little cheer went up from the group. Foolish really, they didn't realise that it would eventually be every man for himself on the sands of the arena. Adora

understood though. Her team were a disposable means to an ends, an impressive feat for an eight year old. Adora preened under her praise, eyes big and shining as she looked up to her benefactor. It was a face that would one day be adorn banners.

"You are all dismissed until evening call." She wasn't a monster, she rewarded those who impressed. "Adora, come along with me, Dominus will wish to hear of your triumph." The girl fell into step with her and the pair walked passed the lion who was only now getting to her knees. "Put this trash away." She threw the words at the waiting guards who were quick to follow her orders.

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Adora watched as Catra hung upside down from the top bars of her cage. Her oddly large feet hooked while she swayed gently as though rocked by a breeze. The blond was seated at one of the long, roughly hewn benches, a trencher in front of her where she scooped out food and stuffed it greedily into her mouth. All around her the others joked and jostled, the loud voices comforting and familiar. Adora wanted to join in but her eyes were fixed on the small figure across the compound. Even from this distance she could see Catra's ribs though her matted and dirty fur.

The lion had been confined to her cage for over two weeks, denied food and hygiene and any of her usual visitors. It was a harsh punishment for failing to follow orders in her exercises. Adora hadn't been there when it happened. She had been taken, along with the very best of her training group, to be displayed before the Emperor, along with all of the newest fighters who would be taking to the sands for their first bouts that season. It was a ritual performed twice a year, have a young warrior who caught the Emperor's eye and you would be assured a handsome profit from bets and admirers. Domina had been preparing her for years and Adora was her most impressive that day, wearing her freshly minted leathers, sunburst emblazoned on the white of her chest and sword strapped to her hip. She stood out in the room filled with blacks and browns and had at once been the centre of

all attention. Her hair had been let down and her eyes shone with excitement.

There had only been one option for Emperor's choice.

It seemed that while she had been away excelling, Catra had refused to be brought out of her cage to train. The gossip among the older fighters, claimed that she had screamed bloody murder and then sent one of the guards foolish enough to enter the cage, to the infirmary. Even after she had been chained and dragged out, a feat that took four large men and spoke of the strength hidden inside the slight girl, she had sat on the sand. The older fighter who had been sent to challenge her had attacked her with no resistance and left her with a concussion as her head was pounded into the whipping post.

That night, the initiates had arrived back jubilantly with the Dominus and Domina. Each one had made a good showing of their skills and obedience. The air of excitement had lasted only as long as it took to walk through the gates and be unchained from one another, only then noticing the grim faced ring of guard and warriors surrounding the whipping post and the naked figure splayed out against it. Dominus' face had hardened to ice and her had moved into the centre of the crowd, Domnina on his heels and Adora had felt her heart in her throat. Moving by rote, her feet took her to join the others in the circle around the post, it was a ritual seldom performed at the Ludus, the fighters knew how to follow the rules. In fact, when she thought about it, Adora had only seen one other person whipped in all her fifteen years at the Ludus, but had seen it happen to Catra multiple times.

The two owners spoke harshly in low tones to the head guard who pointed and gestured, making it clear that something had gone very wrong today in their absence. It was usually Dominus who meted out punishments; repeal of rations, being placed in the stocks or even being forced to trained unarmed with an armed opponent, but it was Domina who handled the whip.

Around her Adora knew that the others all had their eyes downcast. This was an act that was shameful and nobody wanted to bear witness to it. It was too much a reminder that they were slaves as much as they were valued warriors. Adora couldn't tear her eyes away from the tableau in front of her eyes. Domina had been handed the coiled whip and was letting it down at her side. Adora couldn't see Catra's face, but she was sure it was still defiant.

Domina began to pace, looking just as feline and dangerous as the girl who was strapped down. Then, as she lifted the whip high, something happened. She hesitated, lowering the whip back to her side and Adora breathed a sigh of relief, seeing the tension in the furred back ease slightly. Perhaps Domina would give Catra a chance, they had had such a good day, perhaps she would be magnanimous. Then she spoke.

"Adora, you have been favoured today by all of Etheria. Do you know why?" The words were saccharine and terrifying.

"I have been trained by the very best, Domina." She saw that the Dominus had quietly moved out of the circle and away from the spectacle, undoubtedly to disappear back to his business. He seldom liked to get his hands dirty on the sand.

"What does that mean, Adora?" She was certain now what the older woman wanted to hear.

"I know how to obey orders, Domina." Her voice was soft, but the twitch of the tail hanging limply between splayed legs told her that Catra had heard.

"Yes, you do." She beckoned with the hand of the whip and Adora moved forward to join her, the eyes of those around her now following her movements. This was not the way of things.

Shadow Weaver looked at the tall blond teen, dressed in her fighting armour, and thought of the things that Emperor Prime had said to Hordak and her. His praise and congratulations as he

watched the blue eyed girl with his hawklike intensity had made her feel more powerful than ever. Adora was key to their success, she just knew it. Once she stepped onto the sand they would be unbeatable and nobody in all the world would say no to them again if they could keep Prime's favour. Her continual affection for the runt needed to be quashed, it was time to put away childish things.

"Take the whip, Adora." There was no hesitation in the hand that took it from her and she smiled broadly under the mask. "This one has failed to follow orders and now a man is gravely wounded. It will act as an example of what happens when we do not follow the rules." She placed her finger beneath Adora's downturned chin. "Ten lashes. Do not hold back or it will be twenty."

The robed woman walked back, joining the guards and never taking her eyes from the young woman. This was a test. Adora knew that she had to pass. Whispering an apology under her breath, she pulled bak her arm and brought down the whip with a crack and a tear. Blood flew from the first strike, spraying out and leaving spatter over her white leathers. Catra didn't even flinch as the ship came down again, and again. It wasn't until the tenth that the feline's legs collapsed and she was left hanging from her wrist restraints.

That had been two weeks ago. Adora had been taken by Domina, praised and given clean clothes, good food and bathed while Catra had faced cursory medical care and been thrown back in her cell. She hadn't been fed since. She hadn't spoken either.

A nudge at her side brought her back to the conversation around her and she smiled as Lonnie brought her into a joke. It was easy to relax into the banter. They were no longer initiates. The thrill of the first bouts was upon them and it was now only days until they would fight in an arena. It brought a deeper camaraderie with it. Each of them wanted to be on Adora's good side, they knew she was favoured and it was for the best. As she laughed, eyes crinkling, she didn't see the mismatched eyes that watched her every move.

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There had been a little while, when they were small, that Adora could sneak around at night. She was trusted and well liked by the masters as well as by the other slaves. She would grab a little extra food, a blanket from the stores and wait until the air rang with snores to leave her cell and dash to the cage that held her best friend. They were probably eight or nine when it started. Adora had found that the back edge of the cage did not meet the wall and was an ideal place to hide away as long as she pulled a box or barrel in front of her.

She'd snuggle in, making a nest with her blanket on the hard floor and Catra would creep towards her, tail swishing as she moved low on all fours, eyes glowing with mirth in the darkness. They couldn't have a candle, it would draw too much attention, and Adora knew that the little lion could see just as well in the dark. She could always see those mismatched eyes anyway, even if she couldn't see much else.

They would talk and laugh, sharing silly stories that they made up or pointing fun at Kyle. Catra would tell her what she needed to work on in her training, watching her each day and picking up the small faults so that she could fix them. In return, she would tell Catra everything that happened out of her sight. All of the pranks, gossip and shenanigans that occurred. She had been the one who told Catra about the other two lions who had been bought by the Selineas and Snow Ludus'. That day the glowing eyes had widened with joy to hear that more of her tribe were alive and Adora had reached through the bars without thought of how Catra could cut her of maim her. Just wanting to connect, and ran her hands over velvety soft ears. It had been the first time she had heard the other girl purr.

It had become a guilty pleasure that she would indulge in as many times a week as she could get away with. In the summers, if she wasn't being treated to a night inside the house, she was camped out with the lion. Nobody mentioned it. Until they did.

Adora was pretty sure she had been fourteen when she had slept too long and been found in her spot by one of the new trainers. They had dragged her out, bleary eyed and delirious, tearing her hand out of the clawed one she had held while she slept and drawing blood. When the Dominus had seen his prize trainee bleeding, assumptions had been made and she had been punished with missing a few meals, while Catra had received her first whipping. How anyone could think the creature confined to a cage could be the trouble maker she hadn't been sure, but she knew that she had to stop sneaking out.

Today should have been the greatest day of her young life, seventeen and in the arena for the first time. She had won two fights easily, drawing first and last blood from fighters just as green as she was. It was nothing spectacular but the roar of the crowd as she brought her opponents to their knees had been just as seductive as the fight itself and when Emperor Prime had thrown laurels down on her she knew that she had made her Ludus proud. She had expected the claps on the back and perhaps to be brought back to feast in the house. She had not expected what had come next.

Now she found herself, sore and near tears, clambering back over the crates that had never been moved and finding the mildewy remains of her blankets still on the floor. She collapsed on trembling legs, her armour long since removed and her shift torn, and rested her head against the cool bars. Her breath came out raggedly and she choked back sobs that threatened to escape.

Then a hand was stroking her hair, so gently that she almost missed it. She fluttered red rimmed eyes open and looked up into concerned blue and yellow swinging out of the darkness far closer than they had been in months. Catra crossed her legs and leant her head on the other side of the bar so that theirThe foreheads were almost touching. The smell of blood and dirt wafted off of her, but the blond just felt safe.

"Why so glum? I thought you won today?" Catra's voice had changed over the years, become more raspy and low. Dangerous

in the dark.

“I…” Was all she got out through a choked sob as the tears finally started to spill down her cheeks.

Catra inched as close as she could, forehead just able to touch the blonds as she cupped her cheeks with both hands and with reverent care wiped the tears away. Whatever this was it wasn’t victory. She had been angry at the girl for a long time, since the whipping but not because of it, but her anger hadn’t managed to harden her into hate. This girl was all she had here and she loved her, in all of her perfection and all of her flaws. She knew it was futile, knew what the arena held in store for her and that the other girl could never see her the same way but it didn’t matter in that moment.

“I won.” The words ghosted out of her but she knew Catra’s ears would pick them up. “There was cheering and they never touched me, Catra. Noone laid a hand on me on the sand…” It was a strange emphasis and big ears suddenly flattened, fearing what would come next.

“I got taken away from the others, down a corridor. I thought it was a reward, you know? And then I was in a room and there was a man and he…he…” Catra shushed her, moving to scratch the back of her neck with a claw that could easily slice trough the fragile skin but was just meant to sooth. She knew the rest of this story. She may live her life in a box, but she saw and heard more than her naive friend. It was one of the rights of passage of the arena. The winner was bloodied in more ways than one by the person in the Emporer’s favour that week.

“It’s ok Adora, I know.” It was strange to be the one giving comfort even while she wore punishment all over her bare skin, but she was strong as tempered steel because of it and if Adora needed to lean on that she could.

****

Catra came back from the arena just as changed. Nobody had high expectations of the Horde lion. Everyone knew that she was a runt, small and weedy. Nobody even expected her to come back. She had been debuted alone, no other bouts containing Horde members had happened that day. She had been dragged from her cage, roughly washed and forced into a smaller cage on wheels to be taken. The Dominus had accompanied her, going for a meeting at the arena, unprepared for what he would see on the sand. He, like Shadow Weaver, was tired of wasting resources on the creature. She would either pay her way or die today.

She had not died.

The large gates had pulled back and she had been pushed out onto the hot sand. The crowds, more sluggish than on a tournament day had booed and ridiculed this small figure dwarfed by the grand place. He claws had been out in an instant, body low and poised when the other lion had roared out of the gates opposite. For a second she had surveyed his face and seen no recognition there. He was not one of her tribe and she was not one of his. He was early double her size and outweighed her by 100 pounds or more. He moved towards her with languid strides and she knew that this older male was used to the sand and the crowd. It was do, or die.

So she did.

She moved like lightening, fast and small she was through his defences before they even went up. She tore at his flesh with teeth and claws as she moved passed him over and over, wearing him down. He landed a few bone crushing blows but it was paid she was long accustomed to. He swiped at her and caught her ear, drawing blood and hysterical, terrifying laughter. It was all she needed, he was confused for just a moment and then his throat was out and he was gushing blood as he toppled face first into the sand where a bloody pool spread out. Snow Ludus didn’t have a lion anymore.

Catra licked her jaws and locked eyes with her grinning Dominus.

After that, her rations were doubled. Her trips to the arena intensified. Sometimes she was facing convicts who were to be executed. Those were the easy days. She would be on the sand, on a long chain and they would run from her until they tired and learn that her reach did not exceed her grasp. Other times she was pitted against falling stars. Gladiators who had disappointed their Ludus of their Emperor. Gladiators rarely died on the sands, they were too expensive to train to be that disposable but unless you won your freedom, one day you would end your days on the sand. They were harder fights, warriors who knew it was kill or be killed and more than once she came back injured but always a winner.

Between them, Adora and Catra were the more efficient warriors in Etheria. Yet still Catra could not win over her Domina.

Catra grew stronger, bolder and more confident as she spent her time in the arena but Adora got smaller. Each time she came back victorious her eyes were a little more hollow and her voice a little more broken. She would spend her nights with Catra then, the two closer than they had ever been. They had even exchanged awkward kisses though the bars, the heat of their kisses and the cold of the bars combing to flame their passions, that had led to equally awkward fumbling. It wasn't perfect but it was perfect for them.

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The white collar chaffed around her neck, it was locked tight, her hair pulled up and away to reveal the sunburst that was her trademark. She was able to walk through town now, the Domina trusted that she would return and there was nowhere to run anyway, everyone knew her face and her symbol. She couldn't leave Catra behind if she did have somewhere to go.

She had a purse now, her wins mounting up and finally she was able to save winnings passed to her, the hope of all gladiators to be able to buy their freedom beginning for her. Today she was in town with a few of her friends, Lonnie and Rogelio were off to

visit Kyle at the bathhouse he had been sold to when they were young and he had proved no good for the arena. On her own, she made her way through the stands, sampling foods here and there.

She was just nibbling at some pheasant on a skewer when she heard panicked screams and without thought started to run towards it. What she found when she rounded a corner was a pair of cutthroats holding two young nobles at knifepoint. The small girl had a knife poking into her neck and a thin trickle of blood oozing down to her collar bone while the darker skinner young man looked terrified as the knife dug into his ribs. A third thief appeared from the end of the alley, just as she got close, starting to cut the pursestrings of the young man.

None of them were expecting her to pounce at them. She wasn't armed but it wasn't hard to knock the first man away from the pink haired girls throat take his knife and easily hobble the other two. They were not warriors, just cowards. She knocked them unconscious and then used their own shoe laces to bind them ready for the authorities.

She was just about to walk away when her path was blocked by the smiling, wide eyed faces of the people she had saved. They began to thank her, reaching out to clasp her hands when the girl noticed the collar around her neck, making Adora reach up to touch it self consciously.

"You're that gladiator, aren't you? She-ra?" Dominus had decided early on that she needed a more catchy name for the arena than Adora.

"Yes, mistress. It's actually Adora though." She just wanted them to let her head home.

"Oh, call me Glimmer and this is Bow. Come with us, my mother will reward you." She had no choice but to follow the clearly noble youths back along the alleyways, as they towed her by the hand.

****

Adora had been gone for more than a month. One day she had been heading into town with the others, huddling with her in the night and promising to return with something interesting for the caged girl to look at, then she was gone. She had watched the others return, well trusted now and wearing their gladiator collars with pride, all hoping to win their freedom one day. Fools all of them. Catra had watched enough, killed enough, to know that nobody from Horde Ludus ever retired to freedom. They were thrown to the wolves, or lions in their case.

She wanted to know where Adora had disappeared to so badly, but nobody came to her cage anymore, not after she went after Lonnie that time. She was nothing more than a wild animal to them, her kills etched on the wall by her cage to show that she was not them. The young gladiators fought to capitulation, seldom death. The lions tore apart convicts and dissidents, sometimes by the brace, and fought viciously against old and broken gladiators who had failed their houses. Only Adora reached out and she would reach back.

When Adora had still not returned at dusk fear had started to spike in the cat-girl's chest. It was a familiar jolt of adrenaline, it was the spike that lodged in her chest before she was thrown onto the sands to live or die another day. By night fall there was an air of tension around the Ludus. No slave was permitted out alone after dark and Adora was still nowhere to be found. She couldn't hear the words whispering around the mess, but a girl she vaguely recognised from watching the training gingerly set her bowl of meat down and pushed it just close enough with her food for her to snatch into the cage. They were all wary of her as a child and since she began to kill in the arena it had turned to real fear. It was what the Domina had wanted but, when the even, controlled footfalls crunched on the ground she knew it wasn't enough.

Sometimes it was as thought Domina appeared from the shadows themselves, birthed into the light by the darkness itself. One minute there was nothing and then she would be standing before the cage scrutinising her with those cold, dark eyes behind her

mask. On her most angry days, Catra wondered what it would be like to sash through that fine porcelain and see what lay beneath, if she was as much the monster as she seemed. The day Adora disappeared had been one of those days.

Domina had appeared in front of her cage, body trembling with rage and brought up a heavy metal pole to bang harshly on the bars of her home. Her reaction had been involuntary as she jumped and whirled towards the woman with her claws out, only to cower as the make shift weapon was thrust through the bars at her. She hated herself for it and stood taller, glaring at the woman.

"Where is Adora, beast?" The words were hissed out at her, an accusation of wrongdoing.

"How would I know? I live in this cage." The woman hated her and Catra was far passed caring if she inflamed her ire.

"Don't toy with me, you filthy animal! I know she tells you everything. I have allowed this 'friendship'," and how she made that word sound dirty and wrong, "you share but don't think for a moment that I cannot tear you apart."

"She didn't tell me anything. If she's not coming back she left me as much as she left you." Catra felt something like ice in her heart at the thought. What if Adora had just left her?

The large piece of metal was raised as though she meant to throw it at the young woman when her name being called harshly from the balcony by Dominus drew her attention. The bar fell from her hands beside the cage and she walked away leaving Catra to sink to the floor in the far corner of the cage, next to Adora's abandoned blanket.

On the fourth day she had brought the blanket into her cage and curled up with her, taking some comfort in it. Noone had heard about the lost gladiator, no crimes had been reported and no ransom had been demanded. She was either dead somewhere,

that made her shudder in horror, or she had run away and left her behind. She wanted to be angry, but instead the idea that the girl that she had loved her whole life could just leave her just made tears come to her eyes that she roughly dashed away.

After a month, the Ludus had moved on from Adora. Domina had never mentioned her again, it was as though she had never been. Fights had been won and lost on the sands, Lonnie had been elevated to the best of their new batch while the older gladiators continued to swell the houses coffers. Catra had not been brought to the arena in all that time. She was being fed up and worked until even her fur ached to make her fit for the grand exhibition. She welcomed it, if she worked hard enough her mind would be left blank and she would be able to fall asleep beside the blanket.

****

Brightmoon was the second most influential household in all of Etheria, second only to Emperor Prime himself, and Adora could never have dreamed that she would end up here, living in the large mansion that they inhabited. After she had saved Glimmer and Bow from the cutpurses, she had been caught up in the whirlwind of their thanks and their excitement. The next thing she had known she had been stood before the family matriarch who had shown her gratitude by refusing to let the young woman leave.

Adora had felt her heart beating too fast and her breath had become shallow and ragged as spots danced before her eyes. Everyone knew what happened to runaway slaves and if she didn't return to the Ludus by dark she would be whipped or worse. And Catra would be so worried! She had tried to say something, demure and run home, but she had been paralysed by her fears until long slender hands cupped her shoulders and a calm voice had started to talk softly to her.

"Adora, you have protected the heir to Brightmoon. You will never need to be afraid again. You will be free by morning." Adora

looked up, blinking owlishly at the serene face as Angella of Brightmoon called over a guard.

Adora tensed as she heard somebody come up behind her but the soothing presence in front of her stopped her natural instinct to fight. Then there was a small crack and something was falling at her feet. Angella stepped back and allowed Adora to bend down to pick up the white and gold collar that no longer circled her throat. She looked blankly from the leather to Bow and Glimmer who stood to the side beaming at her, and then back to her benefactor.

"I don't understand."

"It is a lot to take in, I am sure you are overwhelmed. Why don't you let Glimmer escort you to a guest room. You can rest and bath, I shall send you some clothes befitting a free citizen and dispatch a missive to your Ludus." Angella seemed so sure that she would be freed.

"Horde Ludus never sells its gladiators, mistress." Adora kept her tone respectful as she would if she were talking to the Domina.

"That may be, Adora, but you have done a brave and selfless thing befitting a citizen not a slave. I shall write to Emperor Prime himself if I need to. You will never have to wear a collar again and you never need to call anyone mistress." The tall woman was walking away, surrounded with her entourage, pale robes moving gracefully around her as Adora was left in a daze.

Glimmer and Bow had calmed their enthusiasm a little, not wanting to further overwhelm the other girl. They kept chattering to her and she was able to get some words out. She wasn't sure how they got to the room with a bed that she found herself in, she certainly wouldn't be able to find it again. She looked around with her big blue eyes and couldn't help the gasp. If she had thought that the tint room she was allowed to sleep in inside the Domina's home was lavish, this was a palace. The room was huge, the colours pastels and golds, a small waterfall trickled in a

corner and several doors exited the main room that was dominated by a large, plush looking bed.

It was that room that she found herself waking up in now. It was a big day, she had been free for almost five weeks but had not felt comfortable enough to leave the property. She had spent time getting to know Bow and Glimmer who had turned out to be kind and funny, if a little overwhelming at times. Adora had been shocked when Angella had pressed the carved wooden sword that proclaimed her freedom into her hand two days after she had arrived. All of the fear of recrimination had melted away in an instant. She had dedicated herself to learning to be a free citizen with the same zeal that she had trained and today she would be going out in the world.

She did miss the Ludus, she missed the structure and the order. Sometimes, she would miss the praise and respect, though people here were very nice it wasn't quite the same. The thing she missed the most was Catra. She felt guilty as she thought of the other girl all alone in her cage, day after day with no word from Adora. By now they must all know that she had been freed and there was no way that the lion could join her in the real world.

"Adora!" Bow burst through the door like a hurricane, his white robes swirling around him and almost tripping him. She congratulated herself for not getting ready to attack him. It was surprising how quickly those old habits had been dulled by comfort and luxury. "Are you ready?"

She looked at herself in the tall mirror on the wall. She was wearing a long white tunic, belted with a simple red thread at the waist and her hair was pulled back into her ponytail. She looked softer than she could remember. Before she could answer Glimmer raced into the room smiling, and rushed to grab her hands.

"Are you sure you want to go to the arena Adora?" It had been the place that she had suggested for her first time out, but she knew her new friends thought it was a bad idea.

“I am. I feel happy there, Glimmer. I will see my friends even if they won’t see me.” She was hoping that she would get a glimpse of Catra. She hadn’t talked about her to these new people, she knew they wouldn’t understand how she could care for a lion like that.

“Well, time to go. The carriage is waiting and I want snacks!” Adora laughed at their antics as they all walked out of the room. They were around her age but seemed so much younger and carefree.

****

The week of the Grand Exhibition brought travellers from all across Etheria to the city. Vendors and merchants lined the streets, jostling for space and the place was even more loud and overwhelming that it had ever been. Adora was amazed, she had never been to the arena during the Exhibition but this was more than she had imagined. She had eaten candies and cakes, tried meat on a stick that was covered in a sweet and spicy paste and was now ogling a filled flatbread that smelled divine.

Glimmer went to the vendor and came back with three packages that she distributed between the three of them before leading them into the arena. As members of the most powerful house in the city, Brightmoon had a special place in the stands, a large box similar to the Emperors. They were close to the action and shielded from the masses. When they got there Angella and her husband, a much smaller man who was often away travelling, were already seated in the plushest seats. Adora was happy to take one of the lower chairs with her friends sitting on either side.

The energy in the stands was electric. There was the same sort of adrenaline as down below in the holding area. She craned her neck and examined the spectators. Some were already shouting and red faced though there was nothing to see, others were obviously intoxicated. It was loud, a little smelly and Adora felt the excitement seep into her skin.

Emperor Prime walked out into his own box and the world went still and quiet. He smiled his benevolent smile and waved a hand to begin the games. Then things that were familiar to her started apace. The newest initiates were let loose in the arena and swords, tridents, axes, and ned nets whirled through the air. There was nobody that came from Horde, they had no new initiates ready. Contests passed and she found herself taking to her feet and walking to the edge as she saw old opponents pummel each other and found herself cheering for one side or another.

When she whooped louder than anyone around her, Glimmer and Bow joined her as she pointed out Lonnie and Rogelio proudly entering the arena, ready to fight as a team again a pair of formidable looking twins. The fight was long and dirty, the sand kicked up around them and smeared with their blood. Lonnie and Rogelio were victorious, she thanked the gods, and the other two were dragged away to be treated.

During a break in the fighting where dancers and jugglers filled the sand while it was raked, she looked again at the crowd and found herself staring at her Domina and Dominus. He barely acknowledged her and turned his attention back to the well dressed man at his side, but Domina kept her mask pointed at her. It was impossible to look away and even at this distance she could see the disappointment in those dark eyes.

She jumped when a hand was rested on her shoulder and whirled, almost punching Glimmer before she pulled back and she was sure that she heard a malicious chuckle over the cries of the crowd.

"Everything all right, Adora?" The pink eyes looking at her held nothing but concern and Adora made herself relax.

"Yeah, just didn't expect to see my old masters." She was careful to use the past tense.

Before anything more could be said the crowd went silent again. She looked across and saw the the emperor was once again on his feet and standing at the rail. The sands cleared and his voice boomed across them.

“Today, citizens, we will see a clash of two titans of the ring. Dragged out of the wilderness, wild and unnamable beasts who are good for nothing but bringing death. Two Lions will enter and only one will leave, a sacrifice to the might of Prime and Etheria!” He lifted his arms up high and basked in the swelling cries of excitement from the audience.
All Adora could feel was terror.

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Catra prowled onto the sand. She had never been fitter or stronger. It was as though with Adora gone, the Dominus had finally seen what he had and decided that she would be his meal ticket. She missed the blond girl every day but preened under the paise. The crowd was wild as she moved out. She was the first released from her cage to the sands, she always was. Usually the place smelt of sweat and blood, the battles that had come before tattooing themselves into the place. Today was different. The same was bare and all she could smell was the flowers strewn here and there. It was although this would be the first fight not one of the last.

She rolled her shoulders, claws out and teeth bared as she braced herself for anything. She was never told who or what she would fight. It never mattered. She would win or she would die. The grill opposite creaked upwards and she clenched her jaw as she saw the Lion of Selineas bound out onto the sand on all fours. He was bigger even than the male she had killed from the Snow Ludus and far more muscular than she was.

She looked around at the crowd as he prowled his side of the arena, both of them knew not to fight until they were given the order. This was a show, a spectacle even the animals understood. Catra smirked cockily, puffing up her fur and swishing her tail. She

liked to catch the eye of watchers, hold their stare until they looked away shamefacedly. Let them feel bad about taking pleasure in pain. Their were beasts here, and they weren't on the sand.

Movement from one of the boxes drew her attention, a white dressed girl stood close to the edge, gripping the edge with a white knuckled grip. She walked closer until she could see her face and her head turned to stood. There was Adora, dressed like the rich kids with her, neck long and bare. Free and come to watch her die. If she had thrown a spear through her chest right then, she could not have made a bigger betrayal to the girl who had held her in the night and touched her with love.

Catra was so caught up in the anger that had started to bubble inside that she almost missed the call to fight. Her opponent had no such problems and bolted towards her like a blur of grey fur. It was only thanks to her small size and lightening reflexes that she was able to jump out of his way and moved across the sand but now she was angry and on the back-foot and this male would pay the price.

The battle was long and brutal. Blood stained the sand and the walls, people in the front rows were spattered with bloodspots and bore Tham proudly. Adora had not sat once and felt like she hadn't taken a breath since she saw Catra notice her and almost be taken out straight away. She had never seen her friend fight before and it was frightening to see what those claws, on fingers that had been inside her, could do to flesh and bone. So much of her wanted to jump down and help but knew that it would only be a distraction.

Catra could barely see, the blood in her eyes from the gash on her face, but she knew he was in just as bad a state. If she could get close enough she was pretty sure that she could take his arm off before he could get her gut. It was cut down to the bone already. She still had one good hand, the other numb and bent out of shape. She started to run, flashes of Adora blurring in her mind,

leapt into the air when something bright blue hit the sand and a voice rang out.

"Yield!"

She dropped to the sand too hard, pulling up so that she would not land the crippling blow. His Ludus had given in, they didn't want him to die today. She was the victor. She staggered to her feet, dashing the blood out of her eyes as she looked back to where Adora had been and saw nothing but an empty box as the Emperor's voice echoed off the stone and she was ushered away at spear-tip.

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The medics had sewn shut her worst cuts, reset her shoulder into the socket, pain that had elicited a cry from her against her will. Her fingers were splinted and wrapped in a ball of bandages. Now she was back in her cage, a haunch of meat sitting at her feet as a reward but all she could see was Adora.

Adora had run away and somehow got herself freed without ever looking back. The blanket was in her hand before she knew it, the last ships of Adora's scent filling her nostrils but instead of comfort all she could feel was rage. Red clouded her vision and the blanket was shredded into pieces. She would regret it later, she knew that, but right now all she could feel was betrayal.

The meat felt like ashes in her mouth.

Across the city, Adora laid on her soft bed and wept. Catra had seen her, had looked right at her and saw that the collar was gone. What must she have thought? Adora never meant to leave her behind but that was exactly what she had done. She wanted to run, to find her collar and go back home. Crawl into her little space and stroke Catra's injured face and tell her how well she had done.

Catra had looked so hurt. Her skin had been torn and her hand had looked like a mess. Who would take her food and talk to her

now that Adora was gone? It wasn't the first time she had thought about the other girl. She dreamed about her almost every night, of soft kisses and whispers in the night, the touch of fur on skin as Catra took away her pain and now she couldn't pay her back.

Tears soaked into the pillow beneath her.

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It was months before Adora walked into the arena again. She knew she was a coward but she couldn't stomach being there again. Catra had not been on the roster in all that time, obviously too badly injured to fight but when she had heard rumours in the market that the Horde Lion was back she had to come.

She was alone this time, a regular set of fights on a weekday. The crowd were thin and not very interested and there were no dignitaries there. Adora tucked herself away into a shady area, trying not to be seen as she scanned the crowd. It was odd to see The Domina and Dominus sitting by the sand, they would never come to a bought like this unless they were deciding a fighters fate.

Catra came onto the sand third, there was still a limp in her walk and her previously injured hand was held close to her side. Adora wished that she could see better, but she was certain that it was still a mess. At least her face, that beautiful fierce face, was healed and the hardness in her jaw said that she would not surrender to whatever was to happen.

A group of six men were released onto the sand, each one armed though clearly unfamiliar with their weapons. They might be convicts or dissidents, handed weapons to make things more spicy for the small crowd. Catra didn't seem to be paying much attention to her attackers though she dodged and slashed if they got close but she was watching her masters with an appraising look and in an instant Adora knew what she was going to do.

Adora was clambering over the edge and dropping onto the sand in the same instant that Catra began to run towards the wall. Her speed increased with each step, ignoring the lancing pain that shot through her thigh. She hit the wall and scaled it easily, bringing her face to face with her tormentors. If she was to die today in a circle of untrained fools, then she would not die alone. Dominus was dispatched easily before anyone seemed to realise that she was even there, his throat slit and blood gurgling out. The guards fell on her then, pinning her down and getting caught by her claws but she would not go down. She managed to free herself and pounced towards the Domina who was trying to get away.

Shattering porcelain was just as satisfying as she had imaged and the shards that lodged in her fist were worth it to see the blood ooz down the woman's face from where a large piece had lodged in her eye socket. The injured woman was stunned enough that Catra was able to lung forward again and force that fragment further until the woman dropped in a lifeless heap.

Hands grabbed at her and she felt the bite of steel in her side, sliding through flesh and bone. She managed to stagger and fall over the edge back down onto the sand, hitting it hard and feeling the warm blood from the sword would spill out around her. The air was coming into her lungs with a rattle but she knew that if she didn't get to her feet she would die where she fell. She wouldn't give them the satisfaction.

Swords clashing made her raise her head and see somebody who had taken her place on the sand, fighting back the guards and fighters for her. Blond hair streaming and sword moving in graceful arc. She knew she must be dying, Adora could not be here, but if an angel had come for her then she would fight by her side.

She crawled to her feet and entered the fray, body quickly going numb as blood sluggishly poured down her leg. She fought, but Adora fought harder and it wasn't long before bodies littered the sand and the stands were silent. Without a word she was being

hoisted over Adora's shoulder and with no small effort carried out and onto the street. Her head bobbed and her breaths grew short. Darkness filled her vision.

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What'd she done?

She had watched Catra murder two people and then jumped in to help kill more. She was a free citizen now who had killed other citizens. That was murder, she couldn't go back to Brightmoon now, couldn't be anywhere in the city. Catra was bleeding over her back and she hadn't heard her breath in a while. Ducking into a small alleyway that led to the woods, she laid the other girl down.

She reached down, released to feel a pulse, and used a knife she kept in her boot to pick the lock on her collar and throw it aside. There would be no play acting at freedom for Catra, she was obviously a lion, furred and naked and covered in wounds. The only hope of keeping them both alive was to get to the woods and find one of the tribes who were so good at hiding.

If Catra lived that long.

The deep wound in her side was still bleeding, the blood looking more black than red now. She tore the hem of her tunic and padded the wound. She picked up the unconscious form again, this time bridal style, tucking her head into her shoulder and managed to get them to the woods without detection.

Adora walked until her legs gave up on her. They were in a small clearing covered in tiny yellow flowers, butterflies dancing carefree. She sagged to the ground, careful not to disturb the girl I'm her arms. A gravely breath from her lap drew her eyes away from the tranquility around her to the glazed mismatched eyes that looked up at her.

"Hey Adora," The words were soft and pained. "I know you're not real but I'm glad you're here…I destroyed the Horde for us. We can both be free now, you see?"

“I am here Catra, I promise.” Tears slid down her face and landed in the fur on the dirty face that looked serene.

“Of course you are…this place is nice…peaceful…” her words trailed off but her eyes stayed trained on Adora.

“We can stay here as long as you want.” Her voice was thick with emotion but she smiled down and Catra smiled back.

“You’re a good angel, Adora.”

Before she could say anything around the sob that threaten to spill out, rustling in the trees made her tense. A weak hand patted her arm where it held her and she looked down to see that Catra was looking off into the trees, seeing something that she couldn’t.

“It’s ok Adora, my people have come for me.”

They had come for both of them, emerging from the undergrowth were a small group of lions. They moved soundlessly, scooping the near dead Catra out of her arms and disappearing back into the trees. Adora felt dazed, one minute she was holding Catra and then she was alone. What should she do now? She couldn’t go back.

She stood and saw a pair of gold eyes glinting from the trees. She wasn’t alone after all. A clawed arm beckoned and she couldn’t help but follow. Whatever happened to Catra, Adora would be there.

“You coming?” The young voice, barely more than a child, called out to her and she followed the lions into the trees.

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